guess I knew that my ordinary life, if I'd ever had one, would never be the same again.

I had a number of helpers or exemplars, you might say, such as the New York architect John Young, who founded cryptome.org in 1996. Not everything on Cryptome is a leaked document, but Young does make it his mission to publish material that governments and corporations would rather keep hidden. They've been attacked by Microsoft and, like WikiLeaks, had a run-in with PayPal. Cryptome is on the right side in the battle over information, but they don't have protection mechanisms for the people giving material to them, and I knew that would be required. Young was treading on the right domain, but he wasn't ready to be a publisher of last resort, which is what I envisaged, using the complex system of deniability I had by then refined for WikiLeaks. It was all happening quickly and I wanted to make sure the curating and archiving were excellent. Most of the work to set these things up was being done by me at various locations around the world, with the help of some old cypherpunks. My old friend Daniel Mathews from the maths department – more of a traditional leftist, a Chomskyist, I suppose – also helped me at that time. In fact, Dan helped me to put together the founding documents for WikiLeaks, and, later on, wrote an analysis of the first thing we ever leaked.

My job at that point was to create alliances. I was trying to build up an advisory board and tap into future sources of data. At that stage the board was more about giving ourselves some credibility and building contacts that could be useful later; it didn't actually sit anywhere and it didn't really do any advising. Still, I made contact with important, inspiring people such as Daniel Ellsberg, and he agreed to be involved and has stayed loyal throughout. A British mathematician called Ben Laurie also came on board. His father, Peter Laurie, wrote an influential '60s book, *Beneath the City Streets*, about underground nuclear bunkers and government facilities in Britain, and perhaps Ben saw something of his father's work in ours. I tried to build contacts with Chinese activists as well. Because we were predominantly Western ourselves, and subject to Western jurisdictions, I tried to give birth to WikiLeaks not as an anti-Western organisation – which wasn't difficult, because it's not anti-Western, it's pro-information – but I knew we'd turn our attention to the likes of America eventually. At first, the corruption in African countries seemed the obvious place to start. Our